IN

THE PREDAWN HUSH OF APRIL 25, A TEAM OF BIHAR POLICE'S Economic Offences Unit (EOU) converged on a rented flat in Patna's Saguna More neighbourhood. Months of covert surveillance had led them to one of their most wanted targets: Sanjeev Kumar Mukhiya, the alleged mastermind behind a string of question paper leaks that have plagued public examinations in the state.

Mukhiya had gone underground after the medical entrance paper—National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate), or NEET-UG—was leaked in May 2024, a scandal so brazen that the Supreme Court itself had stepped in to confirm the breach. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) eventually filed charges against more than 30 people, but Mukhiya managed to dodge multiple statewide manhunts—until that April morning.

Just a couple of weeks earlier, the EOU had arrested Ravi Bhushan, the alleged architect of a high-tech cheating racket in Patna's online test centres. The two arrests spotlight a chilling reality: competitive exams in Bihar have been hijacked by a syndicate that commodifies ambition. In a state with a burgeoning population, one of India's lowest per capita incomes and scant private sector opportunities, a government job is more than just employment—it's a passport to stability and status. But, for a price, candidates can buy their way in. "These leaks are not isolated events," says a senior EOU officer. "They're part of a parallel economy, and every successful scam fuels the next." This illicit enterprise is estimated to be worth at least Rs 500 crore, though the true scale may be far greater, with many paper leaks likely executed undetected.

The EOU has become the state's nerve centre for exposing the exam mafia, currently leading investigations into 10 high-profile paper leak cases that have rocked the state since 2012, six of them between 2022 and 2024, affecting an estimated 2.5 million candidates. At the unit's helm, additional director general (ADG) Naiyyar Hasnain Khan and deputy inspector general (DIG) M.S. Dhillon have led from the front, sifting through fragmented intelligence and chasing elusive leads to unravel both the scale and systemic nature of the scam. Their efforts have resulted in 545 arrests and charge-sheets against 249 individuals in just these 10 cases. The unit has also taken over more than 70 additional cases registered at local police stations, pointing to a statewide racket that transcends jurisdictions and exam boards—from the Bihar Combined Competitive Preliminary Examination to the recruitment of police constables, community health officers and school teachers. What emerges is a disturbing nexus of middlemen, coaching cartels, paid 'solvers' and, in some instances, official complicity.



HINDUSTAN TIMES

THE GREAT EXAM SCAM

₹500 CR.
Estimated worth of the illicit enterprise in Bihar

10
Public examinations currently being investigated

70
FIRs filed across various jurisdictions that EOU has taken over

545
Individuals arrested in these cases to date, charge-sheet filed against 249

A MULTILAYERED OPERATION

Mukhiya was no ordinary middleman. Once a technical assistant at a college in Nalanda, he had long harboured political ambitions. In 2020, his wife, Mamta Devi—formerly a village head—contested the Harnaut assembly seat, drawing over 38,000 votes as a Lok Janshakti Party candidate. "He always saw politics as a shield," another EOU officer tells INDIA TODAY. With the assembly election around the corner, police suspected that "he couldn't resist the pull of the election season" to reboot his wife's political career. Sure enough, he did resurface and was tracked to the densely packed Saguna More locality, where he had been living under a false identity.

What followed was the unspooling of a multilayered scam. At its peak, Mukhiya's syndicate ran like an enterprise: his henchmen infiltrated printing presses to access sealed exam papers, which were then passed on to the second tier—MBBS graduates and the like—for real-time solving. Answer keys were then disseminated via a network of coaching centres or WhatsApp groups to the candidates, some of whom paid upwards of Rs 30-40 lakh.